

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is a newspaper article about schooling:

Children should start school at six

Pupils should not receive full classroom tuition until the age of six, according to a leading academic. Dr Richard House, senior lecturer at Roehampton University, said pupils, especially those from relatively well-off backgrounds, suffered the most from being pushed “too far, too fast”. He said that students can benefit from being slowed down in the early years, allowing them to develop naturally.

He warned that if kids are pushed into formal schooling from a very young age, there is a higher chance for them to suffer lifelong negative health effects and even premature death. He added: “Most children under the age of six need lots of time to play, and to develop social skills, and to learn to control their impulses. An over-emphasis on formal classroom instruction, staying in instead of playing outside, can have serious effects that might not surface until years later.”

The conclusions follow a research study that found that starting late “appears to have no adverse effect on children’s progress”. Dr House, however, admitted that early schooling may be beneficial to children with poor family backgrounds. “There are of course some children from very deprived backgrounds who in general would, and certainly do, gain a net benefit from starting school early,” he said. “But the evidence is now quite overwhelming that such an early introduction to formal schooling is quite unnecessary for the majority of children, and even worse, this can actually cause major developmental harm, and at worst a shortened life-span.”

You are preparing for a debate with the motion “Starting formal schooling before the age of six does more harm than good to children”. Discuss with your group what to include in this debate. You may want to talk about:

- arguments for the motion
- arguments against the motion
- which side you would prefer to take
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Did you like being a student at primary school?
2. What skills should young children learn?
3. Do you think children like going to school before the age of six?
4. Do you agree that playing is more important than studying for young children?
5. What are your memories of your first year of attending school?
6. Why do some Hong Kong parents send their children to school at a very young age?
7. Do you think an early start to school is important for success later in life?
8. Who should decide when children should go to school: parents or the government?